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Culture (OWC): [Chagga \(FN04\)](#)

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Section Title(S): 21. Age Grades

Of all the salutation names with which the Chagga honors a member of an age grade none makes any reference to circumcision. The most important names refer to the period in the grove and to its secrets; all other names are borrowed from the sib organization. The most frequent salutation is ngoso: kafo ngoso as a greeting, nenga ngoso as a petition. Those who have been in the grove together use the terms rika and ngasi. The beseeching ma ngasi (blood alliance of the grove) constitutes a petition which the agemate cannot decline. But if a person is unable to give what the petitioner asks for, he protects himself against any further demands with the assertive oath: "mkombo ngasi." Mkombo is the grove in which the Moshi people let their circumcised youngsters sleep during the last period.

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From the sib organization they took the terms mrata and toho. The members of the preceding age grades greeted them as wawa, wande, sahu, but also as msongoru ("the preceding ones"). Girls and women greeted coeval men with msatsa (brother), older men, however, with ndami (father of the husband).

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A mania for imitating and the tendency toward being regarded as something special are responsible for the changing fashions of the salutations of the age grades. When the influence of the Taita on the eastern slopes of the Kilimanjaro was great, the Chagga took over the Taita salutation, oro. In the Chagga and the Masai languages oro means he-goat. I do not know its meaning in the Taita language, but I presume it is the same. From the Masai the Chagga 339 borrowed the salutation ndawo, which, among the Masai designates two booty-companions in the same age group.

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At the present time, a new designation for the members of the same age grade makes its appearance in the Kibosho district: momo, which in the Kibosho dialect means heifer. It started as a joking form of address among young men, and is now the fashionable word of Kibosho.

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After two months of merrymaking and roaming about, the makilala /an age grade—Analyst/ embark upon the third part of the initiation rites, the instructional part, which is given through songs, interpretations, and symbolic acts. Space forbids to list all the instructions here. They do not contain  306 any important elements for the structure of the age grade, and the ruling colonial power therefore thought that these instructions were not sufficiently important to be officially controlled. These instructions remained within the realm of the sib, though elements belonging to the age grade and to the chieftain's right have been added to the sib instructions. The central core of these instructions is formed by precepts designed to make the young men fit for marital companionship.

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